

IMAT QUESTION BANK: General Knowledge (Medium-Hard)

60 questions · 100 minutes · scoring: +1.5 correct, -0.4 wrong, 0 blank · Question bank · answer + worked solution follow every question

Each question is immediately followed by its answer and worked solution, so this paper is for review and paper study rather than blind simulation. Letters refer to the option order printed here; the online app shuffles options on every attempt.

Section A - World and European history (Q1-10)

1. Which of the following statements about the Peace of Westphalia is correct?

- A) It was signed in 1648 and recognised the independence of the Dutch Republic.
- B) It left the Spanish crown to Philip V, the grandson of Louis XIV.
- C) It confirmed English rule over Normandy and ended the Hundred Years' War.
- D) It dissolved the Holy Roman Empire and proclaimed a unified German nation state.
- E) It transferred the Spanish Netherlands to the Dutch Republic.

Answer: A

The Peace of Westphalia was signed in 1648 and, as part of the settlement that ended the Thirty Years' War, Spain finally recognised the independence of the Dutch Republic after the Eighty Years' War. The Spanish crown for Philip V, grandson of Louis XIV, was settled a lifetime later at Utrecht in 1713, and the Holy Roman Empire survived Westphalia until 1806.

2. The War of the Spanish Succession (1701 to 1714) was brought to an end by:

- A) the Treaty of Nystad of 1721.
- B) the Peace of Ryswick of 1697.
- C) the Peace of Utrecht of 1713.
- D) the Peace of Westphalia of 1648.
- E) the Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle of 1748.

Answer: C

The War of the Spanish Succession ended with the Peace of Utrecht of 1713, which recognised Philip V as king of Spain on condition that the French and Spanish crowns never unite. The other treaties close different conflicts: Westphalia (1648) the Thirty Years' War, Ryswick (1697) the Nine Years' War, Nystad (1721) the Great Northern War and Aix-la-Chapelle (1748) the War of the Austrian Succession.

3. Which of the following statements about the Russian revolutions of 1917 is correct?

- A) The insurrection completed the defeat of Admiral Kolchak's White armies in Siberia.
- B) The Bolsheviks overthrew the Provisional Government of Alexander Kerensky.
- C) The Bolsheviks deposed Tsar Nicholas II and ended the Romanov dynasty.
- D) The insurrection was led by the Mensheviks, who had won the elections to the Constituent Assembly.
- E) The insurrection dissolved the Constituent Assembly, which had been elected the previous week.

Answer: B

In the October Revolution of 1917 (November by the Western calendar) the Bolsheviks under Lenin overthrew Kerensky's Provisional Government. Nicholas II had already been deposed by the February Revolution, the Constituent Assembly was elected only after the seizure of power and dissolved in January 1918, and Kolchak's White armies were defeated in the civil war of 1919 to 1920.

4. Which of the following statements about the Glorious Revolution of 1688 is correct?
- A) It ended with the execution of Charles I and the proclamation of a republic.
 - B) It transferred the crown to the elector of Hanover, George I.
 - C) It brought Charles II back from exile and restored the Stuart monarchy.
 - D) It deposed the Catholic king James II and gave the throne to William of Orange and his wife Mary.
 - E) It gave the crown to James II's infant son, later known as the Old Pretender.

Answer: D

The Glorious Revolution of 1688 deposed the Catholic king James II and gave the throne jointly to William of Orange and his wife Mary, James II's own daughter, with the Bill of Rights of 1689 confirming parliamentary supremacy. The execution of Charles I and the republic belong to the Civil War of the 1640s, Charles II's return to the restoration of 1660, and the Hanoverian succession to 1714.

5. Which of the following statements about the Meiji Restoration of 1868 is correct?
- A) It ended the Qing dynasty in China and proclaimed a republic under Sun Yat-sen.
 - B) It restored governing power to the last shogun, Tokugawa Yoshinobu.
 - C) It renamed the shogunal capital of Edo after the new era, as the city of Meiji.
 - D) It established the first shogunate in Japan under Minamoto no Yoritomo.
 - E) It restored supreme power to the emperor and ended the Tokugawa shogunate.

Answer: E

The Meiji Restoration of 1868 returned supreme power to the emperor and abolished the Tokugawa shogunate, whose last shogun was Yoshinobu. Meiji is the name of the era rather than the city, since Edo was renamed Tokyo; the first shogunate under Minamoto no Yoritomo dates from the twelfth century; and the end of the Qing dynasty and the republic of Sun Yat-sen belong to China in 1912.

6. The Treaty of Trianon, signed in June 1920 as part of the Paris peace settlement, imposed its terms on:
- A) Germany
 - B) the Ottoman Empire
 - C) Bulgaria
 - D) Hungary
 - E) Austria

Answer: D

The Treaty of Trianon, signed in June 1920, was imposed on Hungary, which lost about two thirds of its territory and population. The pattern across the Paris settlement is worth memorising: Versailles for Germany, Saint-Germain for Austria, Neuilly for Bulgaria, Trianon for Hungary and Sevres for the Ottoman Empire.

7. Which of the following statements about Ottoman expansion is correct?
- A) Sultan Selim I captured Baghdad from the Mongols in 1258.
 - B) Belgrade fell to the Ottomans during their failed siege of 1683.
 - C) Suleiman the Magnificent captured Vienna in 1529.
 - D) Rhodes remained in the hands of the knights of St John because the Ottomans never took it.
 - E) Constantinople fell to Mehmed II in 1453, ending the Byzantine Empire.

Answer: E

Constantinople fell to Mehmed II on 29 May 1453, ending the Byzantine Empire. Suleiman's siege of Vienna in 1529 failed, as did the second siege of 1683; Baghdad was sacked by the Mongols in 1258 and taken by the Ottomans only in 1534; Belgrade fell in 1521; and Rhodes was captured by Suleiman in 1522, so the knights did not keep it.

8. Which of the following statements about the Spanish conquests in the Americas is correct?
- A)** Vasco Nunez de Balboa led the Spanish force that captured Tenochtitlan in 1521.
 - B)** Diego Velazquez, governor of Cuba, personally commanded the assault on the Aztec capital.
 - C)** Francisco Pizarro captured the Inca emperor Atahualpa in 1532 and had him executed the following year.
 - D)** Hernan Cortes overthrew the Inca Empire and executed its emperor Atahualpa.
 - E)** Ferdinand Magellan completed the first circumnavigation of the globe before dying in the Philippines in 1521.

Answer: C

Francisco Pizarro seized the Inca emperor Atahualpa at Cajamarca in 1532 and had him executed in 1533. It was Cortes, not Balboa, who took the Aztec capital Tenochtitlan in 1521; Velazquez stayed in Cuba as governor; and Magellan died in the Philippines before his expedition completed the first circumnavigation.

9. Which of the following statements about the colonisation of the Congo is correct?
- A)** From its foundation in 1885 the Congo Free State was administered as a colony by the Belgian government.
 - B)** The Berlin Conference of 1884 and 1885, convened by Bismarck, recognised the Congo claims of Leopold II.
 - C)** Leopold I, the first king of the Belgians, was the ruler whose Congo regime provoked international protest.
 - D)** Belgium annexed the Congo Free State in 1885, immediately after the conference.
 - E)** The Berlin Conference assigned the Congo basin to Germany as a protectorate under Kaiser Wilhelm II.

Answer: B

At the Berlin Conference of 1884 to 1885, convened by Bismarck, the powers recognised the Congo claims of King Leopold II, who then ruled the Congo Free State as his personal possession rather than a Belgian colony. Belgium annexed the territory only in 1908, after international protest at the atrocities of his regime; his father Leopold I had no part in the Congo.

10. Which of the following statements about the reunification of Germany is correct?
- A)** It was completed on 3 October 1990, when the German Democratic Republic acceded to the Federal Republic of Germany.
 - B)** It was completed when both German states were admitted to the United Nations in 1973.
 - C)** It was completed on 9 November 1989, when the Berlin Wall was opened.
 - D)** It was completed in 1991, following the dissolution of the Warsaw Pact.
 - E)** It was completed when West Germany joined the North Atlantic Treaty Organization in 1955.

Answer: A

German reunification took effect on 3 October 1990, when the German Democratic Republic acceded to the Federal Republic under the Unification Treaty, after the Two Plus Four settlement with the four former occupying powers. The opening of the Wall on 9 November 1989 was only the prelude, both German states had been UN members together since 1973, and the Warsaw Pact was dissolved after unification.

Section B - World literature (Q11-18)

11. *Midnight's Children* (1981), the novel whose hero Saleem Sinai is born at the exact moment of Indian independence on 15 August 1947, is by:

- A)** Salman Rushdie
- B)** V. S. Naipaul
- C)** Kazuo Ishiguro
- D)** Rohinton Mistry
- E)** Arundhati Roy

Answer: A

Midnight's Children is Salman Rushdie's 1981 novel, winner of the Booker Prize and later voted the Booker of Bookers, about children born in the first hour of Indian independence. Naipaul, Roy, Ishiguro and Mistry are the plausible alternatives, but the birth-moment-of-the-nation premise belongs to Rushdie.

12. Which of the following statements about *The Tale of Genji* is correct?

- A)** It was the first book printed in Japan with movable type in the sixteenth century.
- B)** It chronicles the rise of the samurai class under the Tokugawa shoguns.
- C)** It is the poetic travel diary in which Matsuo Basho describes his journeys through Japan.
- D)** It was compiled by the court lady Sei Shonagon from lists, essays and observations of palace life.
- E)** It was written in the early eleventh century by Murasaki Shikibu, a lady-in-waiting at the Heian court.

Answer: E

The Tale of Genji was written in the early eleventh century by Murasaki Shikibu, a lady-in-waiting at the Heian court, and is often called the world's first novel. The compilation of lists and palace observations is Sei Shonagon's *Pillow Book*, and Basho's poetic travel diaries are seventeenth-century works.

13. The novel that opens with the words 'It was the best of times, it was the worst of times' is:

- A)** *Hard Times*
- B)** *Great Expectations*
- C)** *A Tale of Two Cities*
- D)** *David Copperfield*
- E)** *Oliver Twist*

Answer: C

The line about the best and worst of times opens *A Tale of Two Cities* of 1859, set in London and Paris in the age of the French Revolution. All five titles are Dickens novels, so the item turns purely on knowing which book carries which opening.

14. *The Stranger* (*L'Etranger*, 1942), the short novel narrated by the unemotional Meursault, is by:

- A)** Andre Malraux
- B)** Eugene Ionesco
- C)** Jean-Paul Sartre
- D)** Albert Camus
- E)** Samuel Beckett

Answer: D

L'Etranger, the 1942 novel narrated without emotion by Meursault, is by Albert Camus, who won the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1957. Sartre is the tempting confusion because of their shared existentialism, but Sartre wrote *Nausea*, and Beckett and Ionesco are chiefly dramatists.

15. Ulysses (1922), the modernist novel that follows Leopold Bloom through Dublin on a single day, 16 June 1904, is by:

- A)** Joseph Conrad **B)** James Joyce **C)** Virginia Woolf **D)** D. H. Lawrence **E)** T. S. Eliot

Answer: B

Ulysses, published in 1922, is James Joyce's transposition of the Odyssey onto a single Dublin day, 16 June 1904, seen through Leopold Bloom. Virginia Woolf is the natural trap, since her Mrs Dalloway is also a one-day novel by a modernist of the same generation.

16. Which of the following statements about Things Fall Apart is correct?

- A)** It is Kenyan novelist Ngugi wa Thiong'o's novel about the Mau Mau uprising.
B) It is Chinua Achebe's 1958 debut novel, centred on the Igbo villager Okonkwo under colonial rule.
C) It is J. M. Coetzee's novel about the colonial frontier of the Eastern Cape.
D) It is Nadine Gordimer's novel of life under apartheid in South Africa.
E) It is the 1958 novel by Wole Soyinka, the first African winner of the Nobel Prize in Literature.

Answer: B

Things Fall Apart is Chinua Achebe's 1958 debut novel, centred on the Igbo villager Okonkwo whose world collapses under colonial rule, and a foundation stone of modern African literature. Wole Soyinka was indeed the first African winner of the Nobel Prize in Literature, but he is a playwright, and Ngugi, Gordimer and Coetzee are authors of other books.

17. The adventures of Gilgamesh, the legendary king of Uruk, are told in:

- A)** the Epic of Gilgamesh
B) the Aeneid
C) Beowulf
D) the Song of Roland
E) the Ramayana

Answer: A

Gilgamesh, the legendary king of Uruk, is the hero of the Epic of Gilgamesh, the oldest surviving major work of narrative literature, from ancient Mesopotamia. The Aeneid follows Aeneas, Beowulf the hero of the Geats, the Ramayana prince Rama, and the Song of Roland Charlemagne's rearguard at Roncevaux.

18. Which of the following statements about the Russian novelists of the nineteenth century is correct?

- A)** Alexander Pushkin wrote The Brothers Karamazov and The Queen of Spades.
B) Nikolai Gogol wrote Dead Souls and Eugene Onegin.
C) Leo Tolstoy wrote Crime and Punishment as well as Anna Karenina.
D) Fyodor Dostoevsky wrote Crime and Punishment, The Idiot and The Brothers Karamazov.
E) Ivan Turgenev wrote War and Peace and Fathers and Sons.

Answer: D

Crime and Punishment (1866), The Idiot (1869) and The Brothers Karamazov (1880) are all novels of Fyodor Dostoevsky. Tolstoy wrote War and Peace and Anna Karenina, Turgenev is known for Fathers and Sons, Gogol wrote Dead Souls, and Eugene Onegin is Pushkin's novel in verse.

Section C - International institutions and law (Q19-26)

19. Which of the following statements about international courts is correct?

- A)** The International Court of Justice prosecutes individual government officials for war crimes.
- B)** The International Criminal Court is the principal judicial organ of the United Nations.
- C)** The International Court of Justice hands down sentences of imprisonment against states that lose their cases.
- D)** The International Criminal Court decides legal disputes submitted by one state against another state.
- E)** Only states may be parties in cases before the International Court of Justice, while the International Criminal Court prosecutes individuals.

Answer: E

Only states may be parties in cases before the International Court of Justice, the United Nations' principal judicial organ, while the International Criminal Court, set up by the Rome Statute in force since 2002, prosecutes individuals for genocide, crimes against humanity, war crimes and aggression. The two are often confused: the ICC is independent of the UN, not its judicial organ, and the ICJ cannot hand down sentences.

20. A resolution on a matter of peace and security needs nine affirmative votes out of fifteen in the UN Security Council. What is the effect of the abstention of a permanent member?

- A)** It suspends the vote until the Secretary General has mediated between the permanent members.
- B)** It converts the matter into a procedural one, which the General Assembly then decides by simple majority.
- C)** It does not block adoption: settled practice treats an abstention as not a veto, so the resolution passes if the other requirements are met.
- D)** It invalidates the vote entirely, forcing the Council to retable the resolution at a later session.
- E)** It counts as a veto, because the Charter requires the concurring votes of all five permanent members.

Answer: C

Long settled practice, confirmed by the International Court of Justice, treats a permanent member's abstention, like an absence, as not a veto: the resolution passes if it wins nine of fifteen votes with no permanent member voting against. Requiring the concurring votes of all five misreads the Charter and would have blocked most resolutions ever adopted.

21. Which of the following statements about the mandates of international economic institutions is correct?

- A)** The World Bank exists to provide emergency balance-of-payments support to countries in currency crisis.
- B)** The IMF supports member countries facing balance-of-payments difficulties, while the World Bank finances long-term development and poverty-reduction projects.
- C)** The IMF and the World Bank together set binding exchange rates for all their member states.
- D)** The IMF lends mainly for long-term infrastructure projects such as highways and power plants.
- E)** The WTO is a specialized agency of the United Nations with a mandate over exchange-rate stability.

Answer: B

The IMF lends short and medium term to members facing balance-of-payments difficulties, while the World Bank finances long-term development and poverty-reduction projects such as infrastructure. The wrong options simply swap the two mandates, and the WTO, although closely linked to the UN, is not one of its specialized agencies and has no exchange-rate role.

22. Which of the following statements about United Nations peacekeeping is correct?
- A) The UN keeps a standing army that it deploys wherever the Secretary General decides.
 - B) Peacekeepers may use force at will to impose a settlement, because they are combat troops of a UN army.
 - C) A mission can be imposed on the parties to a conflict even when they refuse any UN presence.
 - D) During operations, national contingents remain under the exclusive operational command of their own governments.
 - E) Operations are authorized by the Security Council and are manned by troops voluntarily contributed by member states.

Answer: E

Every peacekeeping operation is authorised by a Security Council resolution and manned by national contingents voluntarily contributed by member states, since the UN has no standing army. The guiding principles are consent of the parties, impartiality and force only in self-defence and defence of the mandate, and contingents serve under UN operational command, not their own governments.

23. Which of the following statements about the Geneva Conventions of 1949 is correct?
- A) They protect wounded and sick combatants, prisoners of war and civilians, and have been ratified by virtually every state in the world.
 - B) They regulate the design and use of specific weapons such as chemical munitions.
 - C) They apply only to armed conflicts between states that have formally declared war.
 - D) They are enforced by an international tribunal that sentences states for violating them.
 - E) They bind only the states that have accepted the Additional Protocols of 1977.

Answer: A

The four Geneva Conventions of 1949 protect wounded and sick combatants, the shipwrecked, prisoners of war and civilians, and with 196 states parties they are the most universally ratified treaties in existence. They protect people rather than regulate weapons (that is Hague law), they apply to every armed conflict whether or not war was formally declared, and no tribunal sentences states.

24. NATO's Article 5 declares that an armed attack against one ally is considered an attack against all. Which statement about it is correct?
- A) It has been invoked three times, during the Korean War, the Cuban missile crisis and the Falklands War.
 - B) It transfers the armed forces of all allies to the permanent control of the NATO Secretary General.
 - C) It can be triggered only by a nuclear attack on alliance territory in Europe.
 - D) It has been invoked only once, after the attacks of 11 September 2001, and each ally then decided for itself what action to take.
 - E) It obliges every ally to respond militarily under a single NATO command within a fixed deadline.

Answer: D

Article 5 has been invoked only once, after the terrorist attacks of 11 September 2001. Each ally then decides for itself what action to take, including the use of armed force, since the clause requires assistance as each deems necessary rather than an automatic identical military response, and Korea, the Cuban missile crisis and the Falklands never triggered it.

25. A state signs a multilateral treaty subject to ratification. Under the international law of treaties, which statement is correct?

- A)** The signature makes the treaty fully binding at once, and ratification is only a ceremonial act of deposit.
- B)** Ratification is required only for peace treaties and military alliances, never for trade or environmental conventions.
- C)** The signature does not yet bind the state to the treaty, although before ratification it must refrain from acts that would defeat the treaty's object and purpose.
- D)** The signature binds the state only if the treaty is deposited with the Secretary General of the United Nations.
- E)** The state may withdraw its signature at any moment without any consequence whatsoever.

Answer: C

Under the Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties, a signature given subject to ratification does not yet make the state a party, but Article 18 already obliges it to refrain from acts that would defeat the treaty's object and purpose. Ratification is the act that expresses consent to be bound, so the fully-binding-at-signature reading confuses the two steps.

26. Which of the following statements about the main organs of the United Nations is correct?

- A)** The General Assembly may authorize the use of force whenever the Security Council is blocked by a veto.
- B)** Member states are free to disregard Security Council decisions that conflict with their domestic constitutions.
- C)** General Assembly resolutions on peace and security are legally binding on all member states.
- D)** The Security Council may only recommend sanctions and can never take decisions binding every member.
- E)** Members must accept and carry out the Security Council's decisions, while the General Assembly may only make recommendations.

Answer: E

Article 25 of the UN Charter obliges members to accept and carry out the Security Council's decisions, which can bind all states, while General Assembly resolutions on peace and security are recommendations with political rather than legal force. The Assembly cannot authorise enforcement action to work around a veto, and no domestic constitution overrides a binding Council decision.

Section D - Economics and citizenship (Q27-34)

27. Which of the following statements about the European Central Bank is correct?

- A)** The national central banks of the euro area retain full control over their own interest rates.
- B)** The ECB's primary objective is to keep the euro at a fixed exchange rate against the dollar.
- C)** The ECB must give priority to financing the public deficits of euro-area governments in periods of recession.
- D)** Price stability is the ECB's primary objective, and support for the Union's other economic policies applies only without prejudice to that goal.
- E)** The ECB sets the income-tax rates that euro-area governments may apply to their citizens.

Answer: D

Article 127 TFEU makes price stability the primary objective of the European System of Central Banks, and support for the Union's other economic policies is allowed only without prejudice to that goal. The treaties forbid the ECB and national central banks from financing government deficits, and interest-rate setting is centralised, so euro-area national banks do not control their own rates.

28. If a central bank raises its key interest rates, the expected short-term effects include which of the following?

- A)** Credit becomes more expensive, demand cools and inflationary pressure eases, while the currency tends to appreciate.
- B)** Savings accounts earn less interest, so household consumption automatically rises.
- C)** Borrowing becomes cheaper, so spending and investment expand and inflation accelerates.
- D)** The currency depreciates against other currencies, making imports immediately cheaper.
- E)** Government deficits disappear, because higher rates increase tax revenues one for one.

Answer: A

Raising policy rates makes credit dearer, cools demand and eases inflationary pressure, and the higher yields tend to attract capital inflows that strengthen the currency. The reversed options fail on mechanism: borrowing becomes more expensive rather than cheaper, savers earn more rather than less, and no increase in tax revenue cancels the public deficit one for one.

29. A factory owned by a Japanese multinational operates in Lombardy, and part of its profits is sent to shareholders in Japan. Which statement is correct?

- A)** The production is excluded from both Italian GDP and Italian GNI, because ownership of the plant is foreign.
- B)** The factory's production counts in Italian gross domestic product, and the profits paid to Japanese residents count in Japanese gross national income.
- C)** The factory's production counts in Japanese gross domestic product, because the owners are Japanese.
- D)** The factory's production counts in Italian gross national income only if the workers are Italian citizens.
- E)** The profits repatriated to Japan raise Italian gross domestic product when they arrive, because GDP includes all income received by a country.

Answer: B

GDP is territorial: the output of the Lombardy plant counts in Italian GDP whatever the nationality of its owners. GNI follows residents' income, so the profits paid to shareholders in Japan enter Japan's gross national income; counting the production as Japanese GDP, or excluding it from Italian accounts, confuses where production happens with who owns it.

30. In Germany, Article 67 of the Basic Law institutes the constructive vote of no confidence. Which statement describes this mechanism correctly?

- A)** The Bundestag can dismiss the Chancellor with a simple majority of those present, after which new elections are held.
- B)** The Federal President may dismiss the Chancellor whenever the Cabinet loses a single parliamentary vote.
- C)** The Bundestag may remove the Chancellor only by electing a successor with the votes of a majority of all its members.
- D)** The Chancellor can be removed only by the Federal Constitutional Court, on the request of a majority of the federal states.
- E)** A no-confidence vote automatically dissolves the Bundestag and triggers new elections within a fixed short period.

Answer: C

The constructive vote of no confidence lets the Bundestag remove a Chancellor only by electing a successor at the same time with the majority of all its members, a safeguard adopted after the Weimar experience. Dismissal by a simple majority of those present, or automatic dissolution of parliament, is precisely the instability the Basic Law was designed to prevent.

31. A member state of the European Union that does not use the euro wants to adopt it. Which statement about the convergence criteria is correct?

- A)** Its long-term interest rates must be at least two percentage points below the EU average, and its deficit must be exactly zero.
- B)** It must run a trade surplus and peg its currency to the dollar for two years.
- C)** Its public debt must be below 100 percent of GDP and its government deficit below 5 percent.
- D)** Its inflation must be no more than 1.5 percentage points above that of the three best-performing member states, and it must have participated in the exchange-rate mechanism for at least two years without devaluing.
- E)** It must adopt the euro immediately upon joining the European Union, without any transitional criteria.

Answer: D

The Maastricht convergence criteria require inflation no more than 1.5 percentage points above that of the three best-performing member states and at least two years in the exchange-rate mechanism without devaluation. The other figures are inventions: the deficit reference is 3 percent of GDP, the debt reference 60 percent, and euro adoption follows the criteria rather than arriving automatically with EU membership.

32. In a progressive income-tax system, a worker's taxable income rises just above the threshold of the next higher bracket. Which statement is correct?

- A)** Only the portion of income above the threshold is taxed at the higher rate.
- B)** The worker's tax bill falls, because higher brackets carry extra allowances.
- C)** The previous brackets stop applying, so the tax paid on the lower slabs is refunded.
- D)** The whole of the income is taxed at the new higher rate.
- E)** The total tax due remains exactly the same as before the increase in income.

Answer: A

Progressive taxation works slab by slab: once income crosses into a higher bracket, only the portion above the threshold is taxed at the higher rate, and the tax on the lower slabs is unchanged. Taxing the whole income at the new rate is the classic mistake, and in this setup a pay rise can never reduce the total bill.

33. Which of the following statements about the history of voting rights is correct?

- A)** Swiss women obtained the vote in federal elections before the First World War.
- B)** New Zealand granted women the parliamentary vote only after the Second World War.
- C)** France was the first country to give women the vote at national level, in 1893.
- D)** The United Kingdom gave all women the parliamentary vote on the same terms as men in 1918.
- E)** New Zealand was the first self-governing country to give women the vote in parliamentary elections, in 1893.

Answer: E

New Zealand's Electoral Act of 1893 made it the first self-governing country to give women the vote in parliamentary elections. The British franchise of 1918 was partial, covering mainly women over thirty with property qualifications, full equality came in 1928, and Swiss women waited until 1971 for the federal vote.

34. In a plurality system with single-member constituencies, often called first past the post, the winner of each seat is:

- A)** the candidate chosen in a second round between the two leading candidates, held in every constituency.
- B)** the candidate with the most votes cast, even without an absolute majority.
- C)** the candidate whose votes are distributed most evenly across all the constituencies of the country.
- D)** the party that wins the national popular vote, which then fills every constituency with its own candidate.
- E)** the candidate who obtains the support of at least half of all registered voters, or else the seat stays vacant.

Answer: B

First past the post gives the seat to the candidate with the most votes in the constituency, a simple plurality, even far short of half the votes cast. Second rounds between the top two belong to majority runoff systems, and neither a threshold among registered voters nor the national popular vote decides any seat.

Section E - Italian institutions (Q35-40)

35. Under Article 138 of the Italian Constitution, a law amending the Constitution that was not approved by two thirds of the members of each chamber can be sent to a confirmatory referendum if so requested by a parliamentary minority, by five regional councils or by 500,000 voters. Which statement is correct?

- A)** The referendum is advisory: Parliament alone decides afterwards whether to enact the amendment.
- B)** The referendum can be requested only by the Government or by a majority of the regional councils.
- C)** The amendment is rejected if a majority of the valid votes cast are against it, and turnout plays no role in the validity of the vote.
- D)** If the referendum approves the amendment, the law must be passed a second time by a two-thirds majority of Parliament.
- E)** The referendum is valid only if at least half of the eligible voters take part, exactly as for abrogative referendums.

Answer: C

Confirmatory referendums under Article 138 have no turnout quorum: a simple majority of valid votes cast decides, so the amendment is rejected if most of those voting are against it. The 2020 seat-cut reform passed with about 70 percent yes on roughly 51 percent turnout; the rule that half the electorate must vote belongs to Article 75 abrogative referendums.

36. Italy's constitutional reform of 2016 was put to a referendum on 4 December 2016 even though both chambers had already approved it. Why?

- A)** Because the Constitutional Court had found the reform unconstitutional and ordered a popular confirmation.
- B)** Because the President of the Republic refused to promulgate the law before a popular vote had been held.
- C)** Because every constitutional law must in all cases be ratified by the people, whatever the size of the parliamentary majority.
- D)** Because parliamentary approval had come from fewer than half the members, which always forces a popular vote.
- E)** Because it had not obtained a two-thirds majority in the second vote, a parliamentary minority was able to request a confirmatory referendum, which the No side won with about 59 percent.

Answer: E

Under Article 138, a constitutional law approved without a two-thirds majority in the second vote is suspended if one fifth of a chamber, five regional councils or 500,000 voters request a referendum; in 2016 the minority did so, and the No side won with about 59 percent, forcing Renzi's resignation. No rule makes a popular vote compulsory: with a two-thirds majority the law is promulgated directly.

37. Which of the following statements about the President of the Italian Republic is correct?

- A)** The President may dismiss the Prime Minister at will, because the head of the government serves directly at presidential pleasure.
- B)** The President's acts require the counter-signature of the proposing ministers, and the President may not dissolve the Chambers in the last six months of the presidential term, save narrow exceptions.
- C)** The President legislates directly in matters of foreign policy through presidential decrees having the force of law.
- D)** The President may freely dissolve the Chambers during the last six months of the presidential term of office.
- E)** The President's acts take effect on the President's own signature alone, and ministers are never involved in validating them.

Answer: B

Presidential acts in Italy are valid only with the counter-signature of the proposing ministers (Article 89), and the President may not dissolve the Chambers in the last six months of the presidential term except in the recognised narrow cases (Article 88). Italy is parliamentary: the government answers to Parliament, so the head of state cannot dismiss the Prime Minister at will.

38. In a case before an ordinary Italian judge, the judge believes that the statutory provision to be applied conflicts with the Constitution. What can the judge do?

- A)** Stay the proceedings and refer the question of constitutionality to the Constitutional Court, which alone may declare the law unconstitutional with effect for everyone.
- B)** Ask the regional council whose statute is affected to invalidate the offending provision.
- C)** Set the provision aside directly and decide the case under the Constitution, as Italian judges may do with any unconstitutional statute.
- D)** Rule against the statute by a qualified majority of all the judges of the Court of Cassation sitting in joint divisions.
- E)** Nothing at all: an ordinary judge must always apply statutes exactly as written, whatever doubts may exist about them.

Answer: A

Italian constitutional review is incidental and centralised: the ordinary judge who doubts a statute's constitutionality stays the proceedings and refers the question to the Constitutional Court, the only body that may declare a law unconstitutional with effect for everyone. Direct disapplication is the technique reserved for conflicting EU law, which judges of any level must set aside.

39. In the abrogative referendums of 8 and 9 June 2025, the Yes option prevailed on all five questions, including the reduction of the residence requirement for acquiring citizenship from ten years to five. What was the outcome?

- A)** Parliament re-enacted all the abrogated provisions by absolute majority within sixty days of the vote.
- B)** All five questions were approved, because a majority of the valid votes decides an abrogative referendum.
- C)** All five referendums were declared invalid, because turnout of about 30 percent fell far below the quorum of half the electorate required for validity.
- D)** Only the labour questions took effect, while the citizenship question lapsed for lack of a majority.
- E)** The Constitutional Court annulled the ballots, because the citizenship question touched on a constitutional matter reserved to Parliament.

Answer: C

Article 75 makes an abrogative referendum valid only if at least half of those entitled to vote actually take part. In June 2025 turnout was about 30 percent, so all five questions, citizenship included, failed despite the Yes majorities among those who voted; counting valid votes alone ignores the quorum that sank the ballots.

40. Which of the following statements about the distribution of legislative power in Italy is correct?

- A)** Criminal law is a concurrent matter in which the regions may legislate within the fundamental principles set by State law.
- B)** The provinces legislate on criminal law and the organisation of the judiciary, within the limits set by the regional statutes.
- C)** The State holds legislative power in all matters, and the regions may issue only administrative regulations.
- D)** Since the 2001 reform of Title V of the Constitution, the regions have legislative power in all matters not expressly reserved to State legislation.
- E)** The regions legislate only where the State has expressly delegated each single competence to them one by one.

Answer: D

The 2001 reform of Title V inverted the logic of Article 117: the Constitution lists the State's exclusive matters and the concurrent ones, and all matters not listed belong to the regions as residual competence. Criminal law and the organisation of the judiciary are firmly among the State's exclusive powers, so the option treating criminal law as concurrent misreads the list.

Section F - History of science (Q41-47)

41. Which of the following statements about the first public announcement of evolution by natural selection is correct?

- A)** The 1858 papers were presented on Darwin's behalf by his brother Erasmus, since Darwin was gravely ill.
- B)** Wallace sent his essay at Darwin's request, so the two men appeared together on a stage in London in 1858.
- C)** Alfred Russel Wallace published his theory of natural selection in 1858, and Charles Darwin's *On the Origin of Species* appeared only after Wallace's death in 1913.
- D)** In July 1858, papers by Darwin and Wallace were read together at a meeting of the Linnean Society of London, in the absence of both authors.
- E)** Darwin attended the 1858 reading in person, but Wallace could not attend because he was away on HMS Beagle.

Answer: D

On 1 July 1858 the Linnean Society of London heard Darwin's and Wallace's papers on natural selection read together, presented by Joseph Hooker and Charles Lyell: Darwin stayed away, mourning his young son, and Wallace was still in the Malay Archipelago, so neither author was present. *On the Origin of Species* followed in November 1859, more than half a century before Wallace's death in 1913.

42. Which of the following statements about the Newton-Leibniz dispute over the invention of calculus is correct?

- A)** A Royal Society commission, guided by neutral referees from the French Academy of Sciences, awarded priority to Leibniz in 1712.
- B)** Isaac Newton published his method of fluxions in the *Principia* of 1687, more than a decade before Leibniz published anything on the subject.
- C)** Leibniz published the first printed account of differential calculus in 1684, although Newton had developed his method of fluxions about twenty years earlier without publishing it.
- D)** Gottfried Leibniz developed his differential calculus in the 1660s, before Newton, and published it in 1684.
- E)** The two men settled the dispute amicably and agreed to share credit in joint publications of the Royal Society.

Answer: C

Newton had developed the method of fluxions around 1665 to 1666 but kept it unpublished, while Leibniz issued the first printed account of differential calculus in the *Acta Eruditorum* in 1684; historians agree the two worked independently. The Royal Society's 1712 report awarded priority to Newton, whose own account appeared only in 1704, and the commission could hardly be neutral since he presided over the Society.

43. Gregor Mendel's paper on his pea plant experiments, published in 1866, was largely ignored for decades. Its laws were rediscovered and cited in 1900 by which three botanists?

- A)** Hugo de Vries, Carl Correns and Erich von Tschermak
- B)** Joseph Hooker, Charles Lyell and Asa Gray
- C)** Thomas Hunt Morgan, Alfred Sturtevant and Calvin Bridges
- D)** James Watson, Francis Crick and Maurice Wilkins
- E)** Robert Koch, Paul Ehrlich and Emil von Behring

Answer: A

Mendel's laws were rediscovered and republished in 1900 by three botanists working independently: Hugo de Vries in the Netherlands, Carl Correns in Germany and Erich von Tschermak in Austria, each citing the 1866 paper. The other trios belong to DNA structure (Watson, Crick, Wilkins), bacteriology (Koch, Ehrlich, Behring) and fruit-fly chromosome mapping (Morgan, Sturtevant, Bridges).

44. Which of the following statements about the Michelson-Morley experiment of 1887 is correct?

- A)** It measured the charge of the electron suspended in oil droplets, work honoured by the 1907 Nobel Prize in Physics.
- B)** Its null result, obtained by splitting a light beam with an interferometer in Cleveland, showed no measurable difference in light speed with Earth's motion, undermining the luminiferous aether.
- C)** It confirmed that light travels at different speeds depending on the direction of Earth's orbital motion, as aether theory predicted.
- D)** It was designed to test Newton's law of universal gravitation, and its positive result led Einstein directly to general relativity.
- E)** It detected a marked aether wind, confirming that light waves need a material medium and opening the way to special relativity.

Answer: B

The 1887 experiment in Cleveland split a light beam with an interferometer and found no measurable difference in light speed with Earth's direction of motion, a null result that undermined the luminiferous aether and paved the way to Einstein's special relativity of 1905. Michelson's 1907 Nobel honoured the interferometer and precision optics, and the oil-drop electron measurement was Millikan's.

45. Rosalind Franklin's X-ray diffraction work at King's College London was central to the discovery of the DNA double helix. Why did she not share the 1962 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine awarded to Watson, Crick and Wilkins?

- A)** Her contribution was recognised instead by the 1962 Nobel Prize in Chemistry, which she shared with Max Perutz.
- B)** Nobel Foundation rules of the time did not allow women to share science prizes.
- C)** Her Photo 51 had been shown to Watson without her knowledge, and she refused on principle to appear alongside him in Stockholm.
- D)** Her data had by then disproved the double-helix model, so the Nobel committee excluded her work.
- E)** She had died in 1958, and Nobel prizes are not awarded posthumously, which made her ineligible for the 1962 award.

Answer: E

Rosalind Franklin died of cancer in April 1958, aged 37, and Nobel statutes exclude posthumous awards, so she could not share the 1962 prize given to Watson, Crick and Wilkins. The story of a principled refusal is a myth, and the 1962 chemistry prize went to Perutz and Kendrew for protein structure, not to Franklin.

46. In their famous 1952 blender experiment, Alfred Hershey and Martha Chase labelled T2 bacteriophages with radioactive isotopes. Which of the following statements describes their finding correctly?

- A)** The experiment used X-ray diffraction of phage crystals to reveal the double-helical shape of DNA inside the virus.
- B)** The experiment transferred a transforming principle extracted from dead, heat-killed bacteria into live cells.
- C)** The sulphur-labelled protein, 35S, entered the bacterial cells, showing that protein is the genetic material.
- D)** The phosphorus-labelled DNA, 32P, entered the bacterial cells while the sulphur-labelled protein coats stayed outside, showing that DNA is the genetic material.
- E)** Both the 32P-labelled DNA and the 35S-labelled protein entered the cells, showing that genes contain DNA and protein together.

Answer: D

Hershey and Chase found that only the phosphorus-32 label, tagging DNA, entered the infected bacteria, while the sulphur-35-labelled protein coats were sheared off outside the cells: DNA, not protein, carries the phage's heredity. The transforming principle extracted from heat-killed bacteria belongs to Griffith and Avery, and X-ray diffraction belongs to the later DNA structure story.

47. Which of the following statements about the development of penicillin into a usable drug is correct?

- A)** Howard Florey and Ernst Chain led the Oxford team that purified penicillin and ran its first clinical trials, and they shared the 1945 Nobel Prize with Alexander Fleming.
- B)** Joseph Lister purified penicillin in the 1870s and used it as his antiseptic in surgery.
- C)** Gerhard Domagk's team developed penicillin as the first sulphonamide drug in the 1930s.
- D)** Paul Ehrlich's laboratory mass-produced penicillin as the first magic bullet against syphilis.
- E)** Selman Waksman isolated penicillin from soil bacteria, work honoured by the 1952 Nobel Prize.

Answer: A

Fleming discovered penicillin in 1928 but could not purify it; the Oxford team led by Howard Florey and Ernst Chain did, running the first clinical trials in 1941, and the three shared the 1945 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine. Lister's antiseptic was carbolic acid, Ehrlich's magic bullet was Salvarsan against syphilis, and Waksman's 1952 prize was for streptomycin.

Section G - Geography (Q48-53)

48. A flight leaves Tokyo (UTC+9, no daylight saving) at 08:00 local time on a Monday in January and lands in Los Angeles (UTC-8, winter standard time) after exactly 10 hours of flying. What is the local date and time of arrival?

- A)** 01:00 on Monday
- B)** 11:00 on Tuesday
- C)** 17:00 on Monday
- D)** 18:00 on Monday
- E)** 18:00 on Sunday

Answer: A

Tokyo is 9 hours ahead of UTC and Los Angeles 8 hours behind, so 17 hours come off the naive total. Departure at 08:00 Monday Tokyo time is 23:00 Sunday UTC; after the 10-hour flight it is 09:00 Monday UTC, which is 01:00 Monday in Los Angeles. Simply adding 8 plus 10 hours to reach 18:00 Monday ignores both zones, and the eastward crossing gains hours rather than costing a day.

49. Which of the following statements about straits and canals is correct?

- A)** The Bosphorus joins the Black Sea directly to the Aegean Sea, without passing through any intermediate sea.
- B)** The Suez Canal joins the Red Sea to the Persian Gulf.
- C)** The Dardanelles join the Sea of Marmara to the Aegean Sea, while the Bosphorus joins the Sea of Marmara to the Black Sea.
- D)** The Strait of Hormuz joins the Persian Gulf directly to the Red Sea.
- E)** The Panama Canal joins the Pacific Ocean to the Gulf of Mexico.

Answer: C

Ships leave the Black Sea through the Bosphorus into the Sea of Marmara and then through the Dardanelles into the Aegean. The Strait of Hormuz joins the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman, not the Red Sea; the Suez Canal links the Red Sea to the Mediterranean; and the Panama Canal joins the Pacific to the Caribbean side of the Atlantic.

50. Which of the following statements about major world rivers is correct?

- A)** The Nile carries a larger volume of water to the sea than any other river on Earth.
- B)** The Volga, Europe's longest river, empties into the Black Sea.
- C)** The Volga flows through more national capitals than any other river, including Warsaw and Budapest.
- D)** The Rhine passes through four national capitals, among them Vienna and Prague.
- E)** The Danube flows through four national capitals, Vienna, Bratislava, Budapest and Belgrade, more than any other river.

Answer: E

The Danube flows through four national capitals, Vienna, Bratislava, Budapest and Belgrade, more than any other river. The Volga, Europe's longest river, empties into the Caspian Sea and serves no foreign capitals, and the Amazon, not the Nile, carries by far the greatest volume of water to the sea.

51. Which of the following statements about the highest points of Europe and the European Union is correct?

- A)** The highest mountain of the European Union is Mulhacen, the summit of mainland Spain's Sierra Nevada.
- B)** The highest mountain of the European Union is Mont Blanc, about 4808 m, on the border between France and Italy in the Alps.
- C)** The highest mountain of the European Union is Mount Etna, the tallest active volcano in Europe.
- D)** Mount Elbrus, at 5642 m, is the highest mountain of the European Union, rising in the Caucasus.
- E)** The highest mountain of the European Union lies in the Carpathians of Romania.

Answer: B

Mont Blanc, about 4808 m on the French-Italian border in the Alps, is the highest mountain of the European Union. Elbrus at 5642 m tops geographic Europe only under the Caucasus definition and stands in Russia, outside the EU, while Etna, Europe's tallest active volcano, reaches only about 3350 m.

52. Which of the following statements about capitals and largest cities is correct?

- A)** Brazil moved its capital back to Rio de Janeiro after building Brasilia.
- B)** Australia's largest city, Sydney, is also its national capital.
- C)** Turkey's capital and largest city is Istanbul, which straddles the Bosphorus.
- D)** Switzerland's largest city is Zurich, but its seat of government, the de facto capital, is Bern.
- E)** Canada's capital is Toronto, which is also its largest city.

Answer: D

Switzerland's largest city is Zurich, but the federal government sits in Bern, the de facto capital. The same capital-versus-largest-city split appears in the other options: Canberra rather than Sydney for Australia, Ankara rather than Istanbul for Turkey, Ottawa rather than Toronto for Canada, and Brasilia, capital since 1960, rather than Rio de Janeiro for Brazil.

53. Which of the following statements about small European states and the European Union is correct?

- A)** Andorra became an EU member state when it adopted the euro.
- B)** Vatican City joined the EU in 2004 together with Malta.
- C)** Liechtenstein's membership of the EEA makes it an EU member state using the euro.
- D)** San Marino is an EU member state that mints its own euro coins under EU membership rules.
- E)** Malta, a small island republic in the Mediterranean, is a full EU member state and uses the euro.

Answer: E

Malta, which joined the EU in 2004 and adopted the euro in 2008, is the only state listed that is both a full member and a euro user. San Marino, Andorra and Vatican City use the euro only through monetary agreements without membership, and Liechtenstein, an EEA member through EFTA, keeps the Swiss franc.

Section H - Philosophy, religion and society (Q54-58)

54. The Ninety-five Theses of 1517, which attacked the sale of indulgences and opened the Protestant Reformation, were issued by:

- A)** Ulrich Zwingli at Zurich
- B)** Martin Luther at Wittenberg
- C)** Jan Hus at Prague
- D)** John Calvin at Geneva
- E)** Henry VIII at London

Answer: B

Martin Luther issued the Ninety-five Theses at Wittenberg in October 1517 against the sale of indulgences. Calvin led the Reformation at Geneva, Zwingli at Zurich, Henry VIII's break with Rome came through the Act of Supremacy of 1534, and Jan Hus was burned at the Council of Constance in 1415, a century before Luther.

55. The description of the natural condition of mankind as a 'war of every man against every man', in which life would be 'solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short', occurs in:

- A)** Jean-Jacques Rousseau's The Social Contract
- B)** John Locke's Two Treatises of Government
- C)** Thomas Hobbes's Leviathan
- D)** Niccolo Machiavelli's The Prince
- E)** Thomas More's Utopia

Answer: C

The war of every man against every man, and life as solitary, poor, nasty, brutish and short, is Thomas Hobbes's description of the state of nature in Leviathan of 1651, written in the shadow of the English Civil War. Locke argued for natural rights and limited government, Rousseau imagined a far more benign state of nature, and More and Machiavelli wrote other works entirely.

56. Which of the following statements about the Bhagavad Gita is correct?

- A)** It is the body of philosophical texts forming the concluding portions of the Vedas.
- B)** It is a Sanskrit dialogue between the warrior Arjuna and the god Krishna, contained in the Mahabharata.
- C)** It is the Sanskrit epic recounting the exile of prince Rama and the rescue of his wife Sita.
- D)** It is an ancient Indian treatise on statecraft attributed to Kautilya.
- E)** It is the oldest of the four Vedas, a collection of more than a thousand hymns addressed largely to Indra.

Answer: B

The Bhagavad Gita is the Sanskrit dialogue embedded in the Mahabharata in which the god Krishna instructs the warrior Arjuna on duty before the battle of Kurukshetra. The rival descriptions point to the Ramayana, the Rigveda, the Arthashastra attributed to Kautilya and the Upanishads.

57. The Guru Granth Sahib, revered by its followers as the eternal living guru, is the principal sacred text of:

- A)** Hinduism
- B)** Buddhism
- C)** Jainism
- D)** Zoroastrianism
- E)** Sikhism

Answer: E

The Guru Granth Sahib is the principal scripture of Sikhism, honoured by Sikhs as the eternal living guru, its core the hymns of Guru Nanak and his successors. The corresponding texts are the Vedas for Hinduism, the Tripitaka for Buddhism, the Agamas for Jainism and the Avesta for Zoroastrianism.

58. The Critique of Pure Reason of 1781, which examines what human reason can and cannot know, was written by:

- A)** Immanuel Kant
- B)** Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel
- C)** Baruch Spinoza
- D)** David Hume
- E)** Rene Descartes

Answer: A

The Critique of Pure Reason of 1781, which delimits what human reason can and cannot know, is Immanuel Kant's work. Kant credited Hume's scepticism with waking him from his dogmatic slumber; Descartes wrote the Meditations, Spinoza the Ethics and Hegel the Phenomenology of Spirit.

Section I - Recent settled events (Q59-60)

59. Which of the following statements about the WHO Pandemic Agreement is correct?

- A)** It was adopted by the United Nations General Assembly in New York in September 2025.
- B)** It is a binding treaty that has been in force worldwide since May 2025, replacing the International Health Regulations.
- C)** It entered into force in December 2025, once 60 countries had ratified it.
- D)** It was adopted by consensus at the 78th World Health Assembly in Geneva on 20 May 2025.
- E)** It was negotiated and adopted by the G20 health ministers at their Rome summit.

Answer: D

The WHO Pandemic Agreement was adopted by consensus at the 78th World Health Assembly in Geneva on 20 May 2025, the first such accord shaped by the COVID-19 pandemic. It is not yet in force, since entry into force requires 60 ratifications; it was negotiated at the WHO, not the UN General Assembly or the G20, and it supplements rather than replaces the International Health Regulations.

60. The EU Artificial Intelligence Act, which entered into force on 1 August 2024, applies its rules in phases. In which year did the obligations for providers of general-purpose AI models first become applicable?

- A)** 2023 **B)** 2024 **C)** 2025 **D)** 2026 **E)** 2027

Answer: C

The obligations for providers of general-purpose AI models first became applicable on 2 August 2025. The Act entered into force on 1 August 2024, but its rules bite in stages: prohibitions and the AI literacy duty from 2 February 2025, then the general-purpose AI model rules, with the high-risk system obligations last in the timetable, so only 2025 matches the milestone asked.